

insight ■ quick start

30 Minutes Expert

Driving your graphics card higher

In the quest for a better gaming experience, the route one often takes is that of buying a new feature-packed graphics card. But just upgrading your graphics card and monitor drivers can give you increased stability, more features and push those *Quake III* frame rates a couple of notches higher. And you don't have to spend anything to get these benefits through a driver update. However, if not approached in the right manner, this can make you susceptible to bottlenecks. Let's walk the route of upgrading and see how this can be done the right way!

As an example, we are using an nVidia Riva TNT2 graphics card on Windows 98 SE, but the steps are pretty much applicable to all cards and operating systems.

Revert to the standard driver

First, you have to revert your graphics card to its original driver. Doing this provides the smoothest upgrade path and minimises the chances of any clash between



Select the Standard VGA graphics driver

the old and the new drivers. One driver that works with all types of graphics cards is the Standard VGA (SVGA) driver found in all versions of Windows.

To revert to the original driver, in **Control Panel > Device Manager**, access the Display Adapter and right-click on your graphics card listed there. Under **Properties > Driver**, select Update Driver. Select 'Display a list of drivers' and then select 'Show

all hardware'. At this point, the Hardware Wizard will scan your system. Scroll to the 'Standard display types' in the left pane and select 'Standard PCI Graphics Adapter (VGA)' from the right pane. Click Next and the driver will load.

After rebooting, you will notice that the system uses the SVGA driver, since you have only a 256-colour palette.

Loading the new video driver

Run the setup file for your new drivers. During installation, if asked to overwrite any files, click Yes. When the installation is complete, it will prompt

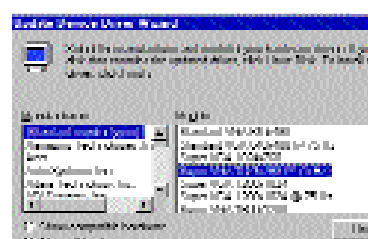


Run the setup for your new graphics driver

you to reboot the system. After restarting, open **Control Panel > Desktop > Settings**. The new driver will be listed here and you can set a higher screen resolution and colour depth.

Loading the monitor driver

Unless you have the correct monitor drivers, you will not be able to run the monitor at an optimum refresh rate and resolution. To install the monitor drivers, go to **Control Panel > Desktop > Settings > Advanced** and click Monitor. If the monitor is listed as Default Monitor, you need to load the drivers for your monitor. Click Change and browse to the location of the driver—it will probably be on the floppy disk accompanying your monitor. If you

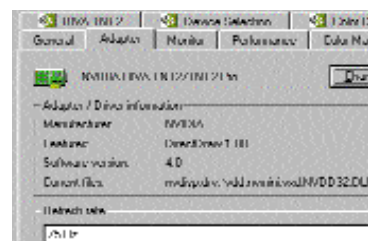


Choose the correct driver for your monitor

do not have the disk, select an appropriate monitor from the Standard monitor types (e.g. Super VGA 1024x768 at 75 Hz). This driver works with most monitors and will allow you to run your monitor at a comfortable refresh rate and resolution.

Setting your resolution and refresh rate

After loading the drivers, you need to set the refresh rate—go back to Display Properties, click the Settings tab and select 1024x768. Click Advanced and the Adapter tab. Here, set your refresh rate to 75 Hz (or higher, if available) and



Set your refresh rate to at least 75 Hz

Apply. If your monitor does not support this change (the screen goes blank), your resolution one notch and try again. When you find a setting that gives a comfortable display, click OK.

Congratulations! You've successfully upgraded your display card's drivers. You are all set to experience better features and smoother graphics performance.

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